

Reputations at Work: Origins and Outcomes of Shared Person Perceptions

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Keywords

reputations, personality, person perception

Abstract

Reputations are immensely consequential for both people and organizations. Yet research on reputations in the workplace is fragmented across a number of literatures. In this article, we first review conceptual and definitional issues surrounding the study of reputations in the workplace. We then summarize several theoretical frameworks for studying reputations drawing from the literature on accuracy and errors in person perception, surveying the Realistic Accuracy Model, Self-Other Knowledge Asymmetry model, impression management, socioanalytic theory, social cognition, stereotypes, gossip, and culture. We present the Trait-Reputation-Identity model as a framework for integrating these disparate literatures. Next, we discuss broad areas where workplace reputations may impact individual and organizational outcomes including job performance, career success, and well-being. We conclude by offering a number of observations regarding the state of the literature on reputations and prospects for contributing to organizational psychology and organizational behavior.

A reputation for good judgment, for fair dealing, for truth, and for rectitude, is itself a fortune.

—Henry Ward Beecher

With enough courage, you can do without a reputation.

—Margaret Mitchell

Is there possibly a construct in psychology as fraught with tension as one's reputation? The wisdom of the ages implores us to allocate our trust and resources based on evaluating a person's character (the stuff of reputations) while at the same time decrying how reputations can be hollow and mired with stigma and misconceptions. Reputations take years of work and effort to build yet are so fragile as to collapse instantly. Having a good reputation is immensely consequential for having a successful career, healthy relationships, and positive well-being, but people who actively cultivate their reputations earn scorn and distrust for their inauthenticity. Indeed, an employee or an organization contemplating how reputations should be regarded is likely to find the collective wisdom at best complex and at worst intractable.

In academic research, reputation emerges as a focus of study across a multitude of fields. In behavioral economics, reputations for trustworthiness are central to how participants navigate resource sharing games. In developmental psychology, researchers have studied how adolescents develop a reputation among their peers and what consequences those reputations have for adolescents' friendships and mental health. In evolutionary psychology, studies have examined the role that accuracy in appraising one's reputation for cooperativeness, morality, and ability plays in evolutionary fitness. In marketing and strategy, scholars have examined reputations at a macro, organizational level as a mechanism for how corporations brand themselves and strategically position themselves alongside competitors.

Against this backdrop, it is remarkably odd that previous reviews have decried a dearth of research on personal reputations in the workplace. Although organizational psychology and organizational behavior have established research programs addressing how perceptions of an organization's reputations may affect recruitment, socialization, and retention, Ferris et al. (2003) noted that "the notion of reputation has been virtually ignored as an individual-level focus of scientific inquiry and as a possible determinant of individual effectiveness in the management literature" (p. 211). Like reputations themselves, aspects of this appraisal 20 years later ring both true and false. On one hand, it is easy to point to mounds of theoretical and quantitative research in management on topics related to personal reputations (e.g., personality, stereotypes). On the other hand, research on these topics tends to be highly siloed, with little cohesive integration across these areas that offers a comprehensive account of reputations in the workplace.

The purpose of this article is to provide a unified treatment of the nature of reputations that incorporates perspectives from these disparate literatures. To accomplish this, we first highlight definitional and conceptual issues involved in the study of reputations in the workplace. We then review a select number of relevant theoretical lenses for the study of reputation, primarily drawing from research in the area of person perception. Finally, we conclude by discussing implications of the study of reputation for employees' success and well-being.

CONCEPTUALIZING REPUTATIONS

Reputations as Perceptions

Virtually all definitions have emphasized reputations as perceptual constructs rather than actual attributes of targets (Bromley 1993, Ferris et al. 2003, Zinko et al. 2007). These definitions accordingly invoke research on person perception, which has an extensive history within personality

and social psychology. As such, perceptions may reflect factors beyond the substantive attributes themselves, including various sources of error in judgment.

Yet reputations are not just perceptions; they are shared perceptions among people within a target's broader social network (Bromley 1993). For example, if Phoebe is the only coworker who perceives Thorsten as a great employee, then Thorsten does not have a reputation for being a great employee. Moreover, reputations reflect a given target's attributes on a variety of "salient personal characteristics and accomplishments, demonstrated behavior, and intended images presented over some period of time" (Zinko et al. 2007, p. 165). As such, we define personal reputations as the consensually perceived set of individual characteristics (including but not limited to knowledge, skills, abilities, personality traits, interests, and values, as well as the composite value of these characteristics) that sustain over time within a given context. Defining reputations as consensual perceptions instills a focus on the strength of consensus among perceivers and at least a strong preference (if not a mandate) for multirater measurement.

Given the centrality of consensus in defining reputations, we begin our discussion of reputation in the workplace by culling and comparing consensus indices for several workplace-relevant attributes (see **Table 1**). We note that which constructs are listed in **Table 1** is driven by the availability of large-scale consensus estimates in the literature rather than their content centrality for workplace reputations. Accordingly, many conceptually important reputational constructs are absent (e.g., specific intelligence dimensions and abilities), and some conceptually less important reputational constructs are present (e.g., the relevance of interview performance for workplace reputation likely diminishes once coworkers begin to observe targets on the job). However, measures of all of these constructs have a fundamentally perceptual lens. Accordingly, considering these constructs through a reputational lens offers a richer perspective on the nature of these measures, and evaluating their consensus speaks to their reputational coherence. Specifically, when consensus is near zero, ratings of targets are largely idiosyncratic to the individual perceivers and no meaningful reputation exists; when consensus is near 1.00, perceivers strongly agree in rating targets, reflecting a strong and salient reputation.

We offer five observations about these consensus values and the research that produced them. First, most research that has examined consensus for workplace variables has done so from the lens of personnel selection, either for establishing the reliability of a predictor tool or for the purposes of applying criterion reliability attenuation corrections to estimates of predictors' validity. By contrast, person perception researchers often examine consensus as an outcome itself in order to uncover processes that lead to the emergence of reputations. Thus, there are a wide variety of important workplace reputational constructs for which consensus has yet to be examined (e.g., is there consensus in judging who is a clutch performer, who engages in counterproductive work behaviors, and who is likely to sexually harass others?). Second, much ink has been spilled debating whether 0.52 is an appropriate index of job performance reliability (e.g., LeBreton et al. 2015), with many researchers lamenting that the interrater reliability of job performance is simply below acceptable thresholds. Inasmuch as we encourage pursuing more reliable measurement, we note that consensus in supervisors' ratings of job performance compares quite favorably to consensus in rating other attributes. Third, consensus tends to be higher when rating more outwardly observable attributes (e.g., performance, extraversion). Fourth, consensus is generally highest when perceivers view targets for a relatively short duration in a shared situation with fairly structured guidelines for evaluation (e.g., panel interviews, assessment centers, creativity tests). Thus, in assessing reputations that span a longer period (e.g., ratings of job performance), where raters intuit underlying attributes rather than manifest behaviors (e.g., personality, emotional intelligence), and/or where raters observe different sets of behaviors, aggregating raters will be especially valuable to improve

Table 1 Consensus estimates for workplace-relevant constructs and selection instruments

Source	Variable	Rater type	<i>k</i>	<i>N</i>	Consensus
Individual differences					
<i>Personality</i>					
Connelly & Ones 2010	Emotional stability	Coworkers	5	682	.28
	Extraversion	Coworkers	6	1,238	.37
	Openness	Coworkers	3	939	.28
	Agreeableness	Coworkers	8	1,172	.29
	Conscientiousness	Coworkers	18	2,400	.32
	Emotional stability	Strangers	41	3,723	.23
	Extraversion	Strangers	49	4,238	.40
	Openness	Strangers	31	3,601	.30
	Agreeableness	Strangers	48	4,094	.27
	Conscientiousness	Strangers	35	3,466	.29
<i>Emotional intelligence</i>					
Elfenbein et al. 2015 ^a	Total emotional intelligence	Student team	2	1,230	.19
	Self-emotions appraisal	Student team	2	1,230	.11
	Other-emotions appraisal	Student team	2	1,230	.21
	Use of emotion	Student team	2	1,230	.22
	Regulation of emotion	Student team	2	1,230	.21
<i>Other individual differences</i>					
Zola et al. 2021	Perceived intelligence	Friend/family	1	282	.06
	Attractiveness	Friend/family	1	282	.37
Dilchert 2008	Divergent thinking	Creativity test	21	NA	.71
	Originality	Creativity test	9	NA	.59
	Fluency	Creativity test	4	NA	.87
	Flexibility	Creativity test	1	NA	.87
Workplace criteria					
Viswesvaran et al. 1996 ^b	Overall job performance	Supervisors	40	14,650	.52
	Productivity	Supervisors	19	2,015	.57
	Quality	Supervisors	10	1,225	.63
	Leadership	Supervisors	20	2,171	.53
	Communication competence	Supervisors	9	1,563	.45
	Administrative competence	Supervisors	9	1,120	.58
	Effort	Supervisors	24	2,714	.55
	Interpersonal competence	Supervisors	31	3,006	.47
	Job knowledge	Supervisors	20	14,072	.53
	Compliance	Supervisors	8	905	.56
	Overall job performance	Peers	9	2,389	.42
	Productivity	Peers	4	205	.34
	Leadership	Peers	4	434	.38
	Effort	Peers	7	348	.42
	Interpersonal competence	Peers	9	635	.42
	Job knowledge	Peers	4	249	.33
	Compliance	Peers	5	220	.71
Dilchert 2008 ^c	Creative performance	All sources	12	NA	.46
	Creative performance	Supervisors	6	NA	.48

(Continued)

Table 1 (Continued)

Source	Variable	Rater type	<i>k</i>	<i>N</i>	Consensus
Selection tools					
<i>Interviews (overall performance)</i>					
Huffcutt et al. 2013	Overall	Interviewers	125	32,428	.68
	Structure: low	Interviewers	11	424	.36
	Structure: medium-low	Interviewers	21	2,342	.51
	Structure: medium	Interviewers	28	3,122	.65
	Structure: medium-high	Interviewers	36	23,997	.79
	Structure: high	Interviewers	29	2,543	.76
	Format: separate	Interviewers	31	2,679	.44
	Format: panel	Interviewers	94	29,749	.74
<i>Assessment centers</i>					
Connelly et al. 2008 ^d	Overall assessment rating	Assessors	7	785	.77
	Communication	Assessors	1	89	.89
	Consideration/awareness of others	Assessors	5	248	.71
	Drive	Assessors	4	198	.80
	Influencing others	Assessors	3	126	.87
	Organizing and planning	Assessors	5	197	.82
	Problem solving	Assessors	4	215	.80
<i>Reference checks</i>					
Hedricks et al. 2013 ^e	Overall	References	1	4,236	.13
	Interpersonal skills	References	1	4,236	.12
	Professionalism	References	1	4,236	.13
	Personal value commitment	References	1	4,236	.11
	Problem solving/adaptability	References	1	4,236	.11

k = number of studies reporting data; *N* = total sample size. Abbreviation: NA, not available.

^a*N*-weighted average of Samples 1 and 3.

^bSample size–weighted coefficients.

^cOverall creativity plus facets combined.

^dPost-exercise dimension rating.

^eGeneralizability coefficient for one rater.

reliability for assessing reputations. Fifth, although we advocate that consensus is a condition for defining reputations, stronger consensus is a condition for—but not necessarily a guarantee of—stronger accuracy of reputations. This becomes apparent in considering consensus derived from selection tools: Although raters can agree to a relatively impressive extent about how targets' attributes have been expressed in interviews or assessment centers, strong consensus in these settings does not guarantee that, for example, an interview reputation will generalize to other contexts.

Generalized Evaluations Versus Specific Attributes

For researchers studying reputation, one of the first conceptual forks in the road that they will encounter is whether to study reputations as a global evaluation or reputations for specific attributes. Such distinctions have been made both at the level of corporate reputations (a reputation for being a good company versus a company with strong customer service) and for personal reputations (having a good reputation versus having a reputation as a trustworthy employee). Both

global evaluation and specific attribute approaches fit within the scope of most definitions of reputations, although they are likely to be pursued for different purposes and entail different measurement challenges.

When it comes to describing specific attributes of employees, the number of particular characteristics potentially encompassed within reputations is practically limitless. Indeed, the content of specific reputational attributes extends far beyond traditional bounds of personality to include knowledge (e.g., impressions formed from reading an academic's research statement), skills (e.g., "she is a wizard with Excel"), abilities (e.g., "he gets lost in his own house!"), interests and values (e.g., "she has a passion for horticulture"), and virtually any other relatively stable, subjectively perceived individual characteristic. Within the workplace, reputations as global evaluations align most clearly with consensually held perceptions of overall job performance. How specific attributes translate to global evaluations is a complex interplay between priorities of the perceiver, the context of the job in question, and the culture of the organization.

Having a reputation for these attributes is related to but potentially distinct from the attributes themselves—i.e., reputations can sometimes be inaccurate by including consensually shared perceptual errors (e.g., stereotypes). Identifying where reputations (e.g., as measured by coworker perceptions) align and diverge from underlying attributes (e.g., as measured with more objective measures) offers a fruitful avenue for research. Viewing a criterion measure such as job performance ratings through a reputational lens opens a host of possible interpretations of its relationship with a predictor: Does the predictor relate to (a) substantive performance variance, (b) ways that performance behaviors have been selectively presented to the raters (e.g., through impression management), or (c) collective biases that raters may have when viewing targets?

General evaluative reputations are related to but distinct from other concepts such as popularity or status (Scott 2013). Popularity describes individuals who are socially preferred and socially visible and generally relates to social acceptance and attention. Status connotes relative position within a social hierarchy, which can arise from personal characteristics (that may be encompassed within reputations—e.g., being seen as intelligent or moral) as well as from one's position (status conferred by being an executive). Status and popularity may be specific characteristics encompassed within one's reputation, and a person's reputation also likely influences their status and popularity. Nonetheless, these three are best conceptualized as separate concepts.

Reputations in Context

Definitions of reputations have consistently emphasized that a person's reputation exists within a defined context or social network (e.g., Bromley 1993). For example, a person may have a reputation among coworkers for being coldhearted but a reputation among friends for being empathic and generous. The context dependency of reputations becomes apparent immediately when measuring reputations: Specifically, who will be considered as admissible informants?

Considerable research has attempted to identify where contextual fault lines may exist in reputations. Within the person perception literature, Kenny (2004) has identified three context-dependent factors that drive consensus (and therefore contribute to the emergence of reputations): the overlap in which of the target's acts/behaviors informants observe, the stability of acts/behaviors across observations, and the extent to which different informants have the opportunity to communicate with one another about the target. These principles highlight a variety of contextual domains wherein reputations may be discrete (but potentially overlapping): reputations at home, at school, at work, in social settings with friends, with extended family, and (for the famous) with the public.

The prospect of localized reputations immediately raises a question central to the person-situation debate: How consistent are reputations (and, by extension, their underlying personality

traits) from one social context to another? Pivotal studies have aimed to answer this question by comparing consensus within and across contexts of acquaintanceship [e.g., consensus in personality ratings from targets' parents, college friends, and hometown friends (Funder et al. 1995)]. In a recent meta-analysis, some consensus in perceptions emerged across family, friend, colleague, and stranger contexts ($r = 0.23$), although consensus across contexts was lower than within-context consensus (Wilmot et al. 2023). After accounting for imperfect within-context consensus, however, most variance in how personality was expressed at work generalized across other contexts (75% on average across traits). Within the workplace context, personality expressions were even more generalizable across the differentiated roles of supervisors, peers, subordinates, and clients (88% on average across traits). Thus, these findings generally suggest that there is meaningful consistency in the ways reputations are formed from one context to another, although some aspects of reputation are likely to be context specific.

THEORETICAL APPROACHES FOR THE STUDY OF REPUTATIONS

A comprehensive understanding of the origins of reputation entails examining the complex ways that accuracy and error intertwine in person perception. Psychology has historically had an on-again/off-again relationship with accuracy in person perception. Early presumptions of accuracy in ratings of reputation quickly met challenges in how accuracy is statistically indexed (Cronbach 1955), in how social cognition errors threaten accuracy (Nisbett & Ross 1980), and in whether traits are stable enough across contexts to constitute meaningful elements of reputations (Mischel 1968). Contemporary person perception research adopts a more balanced view of accuracy and error in person perception (e.g., West & Kenny 2011). Buoyed by research demonstrating that some accuracy is not only possible but also likely for judging attributes of targets (Connelly & Ones 2010, Kenny et al. 1994), scholars have explored the conditions under which person perceptions are more or less accurate in naturally occurring dyads. Yet, identifying whether a particular origin (e.g., gossip) of reputation reflects accuracy or error has not necessarily proven to be straightforward. In the sections that follow, we review an assortment of complementary (rather than necessarily competing) theoretical paradigms and intellectual traditions that offer distinct accounts of what may comprise a person's reputation.

Substantive Origins of Reputations: The Realistic Accuracy Model

Funder's (1995) Realistic Accuracy Model (RAM) provides a framework for understanding how perceivers translate underlying substantive traits into trait judgments. As an elaboration of Brunswick's (1956) lens model, RAM specifies a series of four stages necessary for accurate personality judgments. First, the target must be in a situation in which they can behave in trait-relevant ways (relevance). Second, these attributes must manifest in observable behavior and communication that is accessible to other perceivers (availability). Third, a perceiver must also notice and appropriately attend to the behaviors that a target has expressed (detection). Fourth, and finally, a perceiver must appropriately assemble these detected cues to form a coherent overall appraisal of the trait (utilization). The four stages of RAM can be meaningfully bifurcated: Relevance and availability describe the link between a target's underlying trait and its behavioral expression, whereas detection and utilization link those expressions to a perceiver's judgment (Connelly & Ones 2010).

RAM provides a useful framework for understanding how workplace reputations may reflect underlying substantive personality traits. For example, the workplace represents a context in which highly conscientious individuals may set goals, start initiatives, organize their offices, and meet deadlines (high relevance) in outwardly observable ways (high availability). If colleagues notice

these behaviors (high detection), make correct attributions of these behaviors (i.e., representations of conscientiousness), and ignore irrelevant information (e.g., external delays beyond the target's control or the target's physical attractiveness; high utilization), targets will earn an accurate and consensual reputation for conscientiousness. Although accurate personality judgment is possible, there are numerous opportunities for errors to arise in the perception process. Accordingly, RAM also articulates four moderators of accuracy known by the monikers good judge, good target, good trait, and good information.

The good judge. The question of whether certain people are better able to form accurate judgments of others has long been of interest to multiple domains of psychology (Colman 2021, De Kock et al. 2020), including research on interviews, performance appraisal, and personality perception (Christiansen et al. 2005, Letzring 2008, Rogers & Biesanz 2019). Much of the research on the good judge has focused on identifying characteristics of good judges that are associated with greater cue detection and utilization, although only a few good judge qualities consistently replicate (Allik et al. 2016, Colman 2021). Among these are general intelligence (De Kock et al. 2020), social intelligence [having a general understanding of social norms and contextual demands (Speer et al. 2019)], and dispositional intelligence [knowledge about the correspondence between personality traits and behavior (Christiansen et al. 2005, De Kock et al. 2020)]. Research on good judge characteristics beyond cognitive abilities has been markedly inconsistent, with the few replicable effects coming from interpersonal characteristics such as extraversion, agreeableness, and social skills (e.g., Christiansen et al. 2005; De Kock et al. 2015, 2020; Letzring 2008). These qualities are thought to depict judges who are more effective in eliciting trait information (via relevance and availability) by engaging and accepting targets. Thus, this research suggests that organizations should turn to intelligent and socially engaged employees when looking for the sharpest interviewers, performance appraisers, or reputational linchpins. However, the extent to which individual differences relate to accuracy likely also depends on the characteristics of the targets they are perceiving (Rogers & Biesanz 2019).

The good target. Research has also examined the extent to which some targets are more accurately perceived than others (Human & Biesanz 2013, Mignault & Human 2021). Specifically, good targets are those that demonstrate expressive accuracy, reflecting whether a particular target is accurately perceived on average across judges (Biesanz 2010). On one hand, good targets may produce more visible trait-relevant cues than do others. In this vein, people who are more expressive (e.g., the extraversion amplification effect) and better psychologically adjusted (i.e., have more coherence and consistency in trait expression) tend to be perceived more accurately (e.g., Human & Biesanz 2013; Human et al. 2014, 2019). On the other hand, good targets may also induce more accurate perceptions by drawing greater attention to themselves, thereby increasing detection and utilization of cues. For example, those who occupy positions of greater social standing and power, who are more socially dominant, and who are more physically attractive tend to be perceived more accurately (Mignault & Human 2021). Notably, research has suggested that there is more variability in accuracy of the good target than that typically observed for the good judge (Human & Biesanz 2013). Accordingly, good targets stand out as individuals for whom workplace reputations will reach the strongest consensus and be most accurate.

Good traits. Reputations are also likely to be more accurate for some traits than for others (John & Robins 1993, Krzyzaniak & Letzring 2021). Observability describes traits characterized by external behaviors and expressions, which tend to be more accurately judged across raters (Vazire 2010). Among the Big Five, extraversion stands out as a particularly observable trait that can even be somewhat accurately assessed by raters with even minimal contact with a given target

(Beer & Watson 2008, 2010). By contrast, in comprising more internally held thoughts and feelings, neuroticism and openness are lower on observability (Funder & Colvin 1988). In addition, evaluation refers to the extent to which possessing a quality would reflect either particularly well or particularly poorly on a target person, versus those that are more neutral in their level of social desirability (Krzyzaniak & Letzring 2021). Although some studies have observed lower accuracy among more evaluative traits such as agreeableness and conscientiousness (e.g., John & Robins 1993), others have failed to find an association between evaluativeness and judgmental accuracy (e.g., de Vries et al. 2016).

Good information. Good information encompasses both the quantity and the quality of information that a target emits and is perceived by (Beer 2021, Letzring et al. 2006). With respect to quantity of information, greater degrees of acquaintance or intimacy are associated with stronger accuracy (e.g., Biesanz et al. 2007, Connelly & Ones 2010, Funder & Colvin 1988), particularly for traits that are typically lower in observability (e.g., neuroticism). Information quantity is thought to operate through increased opportunity for the target to engage in trait-relevant information (Beer 2021). However, information quality may be more important than sheer quantity, as mere exposure to a target over time has not been shown to drastically increase accuracy (e.g., Brown & Bernieri 2017, Paulhus & Bruce 1992). Rather, intimate acquaintanceship appears to most greatly affect accurate judgments because close others tend to see the target in a wider variety of trait-relevant contexts (e.g., Allik et al. 2016, Hirschmüller et al. 2015). Even among strangers, providing brief trait-relevant information (e.g., a self-descriptive statement of values or personal facts) increased the overall accuracy of perceiver ratings of the target's agreeableness (Beer & Brooks 2011, Beer & Watson 2008). Given the relative dearth of studies examining information quality as a moderator of accuracy, this is a ripe area for future research.

THE SELF-OTHER KNOWLEDGE ASYMMETRY MODEL

Researchers have also come to recognize that self- or informant-rating sources may be better suited than are others for rating certain personality domains or for predicting particular criteria. Vazire's (2010) Self-Other Knowledge Asymmetry (SOKA) model borrows from the logic of the Johari window (Luft & Ingham 1955) (see **Figure 1**), which divides characteristics of a target (e.g., personality traits) into four quadrants reflecting differential access to information. The Arena captures aspects of targets commonly perceived by others and also recognized by the target themselves. In contrast, the Blind Spot encapsulates characteristics recognized by perceivers but that the target themselves does not recognize. Conversely, the Façade reflects characteristics that employees may possess that are not readily accessible to those around them. Finally, some Unknown characteristics may not be recognized by the target themselves or by perceivers.

The SOKA model posits that two major features of traits modulate the extent to which self-versus informant reports of personality will provide more accurate personality judgments: observability and evaluativeness. Specifically, SOKA argues that targets themselves will provide more predictive accuracy when rating traits that are lower in observability, whereas predictive accuracy will be comparable across self and informants for traits that are higher in observability. This asymmetry in accuracy for low (versus high) visibility traits arises as a result of the privileged access that the self has to the target's internal states (i.e., thoughts, feelings, motives), which might not be manifest in observable behaviors or otherwise communicated to others. However, for highly evaluative traits, perceivers are generally expected to provide more predictive accuracy than targets' self-ratings because targets are subject to a host of self-enhancement biases that interfere with accurate self-judgment. Relative to friendship biases that can affect informant reports (Leising et al. 2010, 2014), self-enhancement biases are viewed as more detrimental to accurate trait perceptions

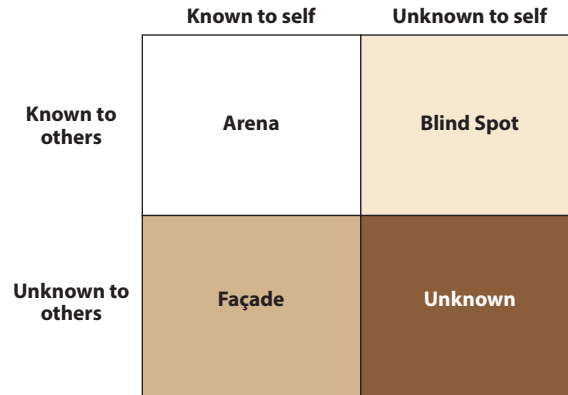


Figure 1
 The Johari window, a conceptual model combining personality information known versus unknown to self and to others. Figure based on Luft & Ingham (1955) and adapted from McAbee & Connelly (2016) with permission from the American Psychological Association; no further reproduction or distribution is permitted.

(Bollich et al. 2015, John & Robins 1994). These propositions for the effects of observability and evaluativeness have largely been supported in predicting behaviors in the lab and naturally occurring settings: The self was more accurate when rating low-observability, low-evaluativeness traits (i.e., neuroticism-related traits); close observers were more accurate when rating low-observability, high-evaluativeness traits (i.e., intellect-related traits); and all sources were equally accurate when rating high-observability, low-evaluativeness traits (i.e., extraversion-related traits) (see Beer & Vazire 2017, Vazire 2010).

The SOKA model provides a theoretical framework through which organizational researchers might consider which sources (e.g., applicants, close informants, unacquainted raters) might be best suited for rating different traits and thus might also have potential implications for the design of multisource selection and feedback systems. For example, it is clearly evident that extraversion-relevant behaviors are the most accessible to raters from all sources. As such, organizational researchers and practitioners have a wide variety of options for how best to assess extraversion: through self- and close informant reports or through direct interactions with the candidate (e.g., interviews or assessment centers where raters are previously unacquainted with the applicants). For other traits, the story may be more nuanced. Neuroticism, in particular, may be best assessed by the applicants themselves through self-report scales. Conversely, observable, highly evaluative traits (e.g., intellect) may be better assessed through alternative methods and by external sources (e.g., close informants), given the propensity for self-enhancement on such traits. Some combination of self- and informant ratings may be appropriate for traits that fall within the moderate range on observability and evaluativeness (e.g., conscientiousness, agreeableness), as different informants may provide unique insights to assessing the internal (e.g., thoughts, feelings, motives) versus external (e.g., behaviors, communication) indicators of such traits.

Impression Management

The above substantive approaches to reputations focus on how underlying traits are authentically expressed in behaviors. However, people may manage their reputations in more active ways (Bromley 1993). This can occur through unconscious processes, such as self-deceptive enhancement, or through more overt mechanisms, such as impression management (Paulhus 1984). Here, we focus on those intentional processes that actors engage in to convey a desired impression to

perceivers. Specifically, impression management reflects a variety of tactics (e.g., nonverbal cues, verbal communications, behaviors) that people engage in to actively shape the impressions that others form (e.g., Bozeman & Kacmar 1997).

People manage impressions for two primary reasons: (a) to obtain desired outcomes from the social environment (or to avoid undesired outcomes) and (b) for the purposes of identity construction and self-verification (Leary & Kowalski 1990). For example, an interviewee may engage in self-promotion tactics to appear competent and likable to increase their chances of obtaining employment (i.e., obtaining desired outcomes). In this way, impression management represents an attempt by the employee to communicate a desired reputation among others, where positive reputations may serve an important function for enhancing the employee's self-esteem. In addition, such impression management of reputations constitutes an important element of organizational politics that may promote one's status (e.g., Ferris et al. 2003, Zinko et al. 2007). Yet not all attempts at impression management are designed to obtain material benefits. Impression management can also serve an important self-regulatory function in that people are motivated to be seen in ways that are consistent with their own self-image, even if that image may be negative (Swann 2011).

Within the organizational literature, impression management has been primarily studied within the contexts of employment interviews and performance appraisals (Bolino et al. 2016). In these contexts, employees' and applicants' attempts to manage their reputations are related to a variety of organizational and individual outcomes (Bolino et al. 2008). Indeed, research has shown that the use of influence tactics (e.g., ingratiation) can lead to positive interview outcomes and higher performance ratings (Higgins et al. 2003), although the long-term consequences of impression management in organizations are as of yet underexplored (but see Bolino et al. 2014). As such, we echo calls for additional research on how employees' attempts to communicate specific reputations develop and relate to organizational outcomes (e.g., performance ratings, status) over time (Bolino et al. 2016). In addition, we note some similarities here between the characteristics that are associated with effective impression management and those that are related to higher degrees of judgmental accuracy (e.g., social skills, dispositional intelligence, status). As such, future research might seek to more closely align the literatures on impression management and person perception to answer questions relevant to organizations and their members (e.g., how does a target's impression management impact accuracy in perceivers' judgments?).

Socioanalytic Theory

An alternative perspective on personality and reputations comes from Hogan's (1996, Hogan & Blickle 2013) socioanalytic theory. Socioanalytic theory derives from two primary assumptions arising from evolutionary psychology: (a) that people live and work in groups and (b) that such groups are characterized by a status hierarchy. From these generalizations, socioanalytic theory argues that human interactions are driven by two competing motivations: the need to get ahead and the need to get along. It is within this context that reputations (i.e., personality) operate, wherein social interaction involves the exchange of status and belonging to satisfy an individual's needs. Socioanalytic theory differentiates personality from the perspective of the actor (i.e., identity) from personality from the perspective of the perceiver (i.e., reputation). Specifically, socioanalytic theory argues that identity is composed of an individual's values and motives, which are manifest through self-presentation behaviors. Rather than self-reports reflecting accurate self-reflections, socioanalytic theory posits that self-reports reflect the respondent's desired self-image. Conversely, perceivers primarily derive their judgments by reflecting on a target's past behaviors (and the implications of such behaviors) and are therefore considered to be less biased than are typical self-reports of personality. Whereas our preceding sections have distinguished between underlying substantive attributes and impression management as sources of reputations,

socioanalytic theory makes no such distinction: Personality itself reflects the strategies a person uses to manage their impressions and reputation (Johnson & Hogan 2006).

Socioanalytic theory holds important implications for organizational researchers and practitioners. The most apparent implication of socioanalytic theory relates to the sources that provide the most relevant information about an applicant's personality traits—informant reports. Because personality (as reputations) is most directly observed by others, and because applicants themselves are motivated to convey an ideal self-image, informant reports are likely to provide the most accurate and valid assessments of a target's personality. Consistent with the expectations of socioanalytic theory, meta-analytic findings show that informant reports of the Big Five demonstrate stronger relations with employee performance outcomes than do self-reports of these traits (Connelly & Ones 2010, Oh et al. 2011), although the magnitude of these informant report advantages varies depending on the trait examined and specific meta-analytic sample characteristics.

Stereotypes, Errors, and Biases

There are also ample sources of distortion and bias in reputations that originate with perceivers. Two methodological notes about research on person perception errors are worth prefacing here. First, much of this research has studied perceivers with relatively limited acquaintance with targets. Given the limited scope of observation, it has been impressive that such thin slice ratings can predict consequential life outcomes when aggregated across multiple perceivers (Ambady & Rosenthal 1992, Giacomin & Rule 2020). In other paradigms, researchers have studied person perception errors by experimentally manipulating cues about a target that are then presented to raters. Both thin slice research and experimental manipulations are powerful research tools that provide insight into how perceivers use (and misuse) person perception cues. Although these studies have important workplace implications for forming first impressions (e.g., during a job interview or when meeting a new employee), more extrapolation is involved in considering effects from these studies among targets' longer-term acquaintances.

Second, many of these social cognition errors exist at the level of individual perceivers or at the dyadic level of the target-perceiver relationship. For example, a perceiver may tend to be systematically more lenient or harsh in rating targets [tendencies termed perceiver effects (Kenny 2019)] and may provide more positively biased but less accurate ratings of targets whom they like (Leising et al. 2010). Many such errors at the level of the individual perceiver or target-perceiver dyad should not aggregate across perceivers and therefore (generally) should not affect reputations. By contrast, some social cognition errors capture systematic cue misuse that extends across perceivers and accordingly are likely to distort and bias reputations at large. We focus here on these more systematic distortions whose impact is likely to aggregate across individual perceivers to broader reputations.

Stereotypes and implicit biases. Among the most studied errors in forming judgments of others are stereotypes. A wealth of social cognition research suggests that perceivers seek to reduce the complex amount of information available about a target individual by activating an associated social category and imposed stereotyped attributes associated with the category on their perception of the target (Allport 1954, Macrae & Bodenhausen 2000). Perceivers can hold stereotypes based on myriad potential aspects of social identity, including the intersection of these multiple identities (Kang & Bodenhausen 2015). Often, stereotypes may represent the first aspects of person judgment that occur, as when based on physical appearance and other immediately visible qualities (e.g., gender, race, age). In other instances, stereotypes may be ambiguous until targets disclose their group membership (e.g., sexual orientation, nationality, or religion). The effects of stereotypes are most pronounced among perceivers with few opportunities to observe targets,

with these effects hypothesized to diminish through repeated observations (Chan & Mendelsohn 2010, Kenny 2004). When stereotypes are commonly held, however, they stand to affect not only individuals' perceptions but also broader reputations consensually perceived.

Although stereotypes can exist for any group with regard to any individual difference characteristic, psychologists have worked to identify underlying dimensions that differentiate group-level stereotypes. The Stereotype Content Model (SCM) (Cuddy et al. 2008) has emphasized two dimensions: warmth (encompassing morality, trustworthiness, sincerity, kindness, and friendliness) and competence (encompassing efficacy, skill, creativity, confidence, and intelligence). Accordingly, warmth and competence in the SCM correspond to anticipatory judgments made about whether others' intentions are positive and likely to be efficacious. Stereotypes also provoke distinct patterns of behavior (discrimination) corresponding to being active/passive and helpful/harmful. As a result, stereotypes may impact not only judgments that a perceiver makes but also the situations in which a target person chronically interacts (e.g., a target being generally admired and actively helped versus being generally envied and actively harmed). If perceivers also are insensitive to these situational differences created by negative stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination that a target faces, perceivers' judgments may potentially misattribute situational factors (e.g., a coworker being condescending to the target) to personality qualities of the target (e.g., "she is a hostile person"). Accordingly, the impact of stereotypes on workplace reputations may be a potential avenue for discrimination.

In the past decade, contention has risen in the stereotype literature challenging the tendency to equate using stereotypes with forming inaccurate perceptions. Although researchers have long acknowledged that stereotypes may have a kernel of truth (Allport 1954), Jussim (2012, 2017) has argued that (a) stereotypes can impact judgments but that (b) many—but not all—stereotypes are strongly accurate at the group level, and (c) the biasing effects of stereotypes on naturally occurring judgments are "weak, fragile, and fleeting" (Jussim 2017, p. 1). Rejoinders to the stereotype accuracy perspective have argued that stereotypes are problematic (and are inherently inaccurate) when endorsed as generic statements (i.e., assigning an attribute ubiquitously to all members of a group) rather than probabilistically (i.e., referring to a likelihood of an attribute relating to a target conditioned on group membership) and when they inhibit the accrual of more individuating information about a target (Bian & Cimpian 2017). In addition, even if the biasing effects of stereotypes constitute weak effect sizes [r 's between 0.10 and 0.20 (Jussim 2017)], relative to the overall consensus of perceptions (see **Table 1**), stereotype bias may constitute a practically significant effect on reputation generation when multiplied across the number of perceivers with whom a target interacts in a day. Accordingly, models that are effective in separating the accuracy-versus bias-promoting effects of stereotypes are well poised to contribute to understanding the origins of reputation (Hall & Goh 2017).

First impressions and the primacy effect. One of the most entrenched findings in social cognition is the primacy effect, suggesting that perceivers attend most closely to early information gleaned about a target. The primacy effect has been attributed to a variety of causes, including that participants may have a better memory for information presented first (Digirolamo & Hintzman 1997) or that they may attend more closely to the first information presented (Hendrick & Costantini 1970). However, subsequent replications of the primacy effect have been mixed, such that the effect is variable and subject to a number of contextual factors (Sullivan 2019). Nonetheless, such social cognition research on the primacy effect has reified commonsense wisdom that a first impression lasts a lifetime. The primacy effect has had important implications for how employees process interpersonal perceptions in the workplace, ranging from making a good initial impression in an interview to how new job entrants should present themselves on the first day to what information is considered in providing job performance ratings.

Notably, nearly all research on the primacy effect for interpersonal perception has involved presenting perceivers with only a list of trait descriptors of a hypothetical target. By contrast, participants in a recent study observed a series of videos of targets' behavior and provided personality perceptions after each video and an overall rating (Wiedenroth et al. 2021). This study found no evidence of a primacy effect of initial impressions being more influential than later impressions; rather, perceptions appeared to aggregate across viewings of behavioral episodes such that later judgments were more influential for overall appraisals. However, the authors note that their paradigms involved no interactions between targets and perceivers, so (unlike real life) there was no possibility for perceivers' initial judgments to affect their interactions with targets.

Systematic cue misuse. Decades of research in social cognition have explored systematic distortions that tend to occur in how perceivers use and interpret cues. From the perspective of the lens model (Brunswik 1956) and other models of person perception, accurate perceptions occur when (a) target attributes are expressed in observable cues and (b) perceivers notice these cues and implicitly attach proportionate weight to these cues in forming judgments of the attribute. From this perspective, the weights linking cues to perceptions constitute a perceiver's implicit personality theory (Schneider 1973), which, if accurate, will promote accuracy in ratings. Perceivers are inclined to instantaneously and spontaneously draw on such implicit personality theories in forming impressions of targets (Uleman et al. 2008). However, it is also possible that incorrect implicit personality theories that are commonly held among perceivers may create consensus in reputations (despite sacrificing accuracy). For example, if perceivers generally hold the false implicit personality theory that socially reserved targets are nervous, an introvert may undeservedly earn a reputation for being anxious and stress intolerant.

Within the field of personality, research has compared the dimensional structure of such implicit personality theories (i.e., perceivers' assumptions of which traits cluster together) to that of the co-occurrence of traits and their expression. Borkenau (1992) described strong overlap in these structures, suggesting that implicit personality theories have some degree of accuracy (although semantic similarities between particular attributes can inflate estimates of their co-occurrence). Nonetheless, more contemporary research has highlighted the ways that halo bias, positivity bias, and negativity bias can impact person perception (Gräf & Unkelbach 2016). Similarly, Goodwin et al. (2014) found that cues about a target's morality tend to supersede judgments about warmth and ability in overall impression formation. This research provides a useful reminder that a single behavioral cue can trigger multiple trait perceptions, often from theoretically distinct attributes.

Gossip and the Social Networks of Reputation

In addition to direct observations of behaviors, reputations can also form indirectly as a result of communications among perceivers about a target, meaning that reputations exist within the context of a broader social network (Craik 2008). In particular, gossip encompasses such informal and evaluative communication between perceivers about a target individual who is not present (Dores Cruz et al. 2021). Although gossip is often assumed to be negative, false, and maliciously motivated, gossip is not always (and perhaps relatively rarely) so deviant (Brady et al. 2017). Indeed, research has highlighted that gossip serves multiple functions that can be grouped as information exchange, ego enhancement, social integration, and social segregation (Sun et al. 2023). In this way, gossip has been described as a distributed process of social cognition that serves evolutionary functions for groups in sharing information and in promoting group cohesion (Smith & Collins 2009).

Notably, gossip and communication between perceivers have long been recognized to increase consensus in reputations as perceivers amalgamate this information with their direct observations (Kenny 2019). For example, Costello & Srivastava (2021) studied the development of

microreputations in the lab in which (a) previously unacquainted dyads interacted and then (b) they described their impressions to naïve third parties, allowing the researchers to separate direct reputations from hearsay reputations. Hearsay reputations reached strong consensus with direct reputations and attained modest accuracy. Compared to other acquaintanceship contexts (e.g., family, friends, or academic contexts), workplace reputations seem particularly rife to be affected by gossip in that the opportunities to gossip about a coworker likely far outnumber the opportunities to directly observe that coworker's behavior. It remains somewhat unclear how much of workplace reputations stems from direct observations versus from gossip/communication. Extant research suggests that this will likely vary by (a) targets, (b) attributes, and (c) workplace contexts. For example, individuals with high social status within a group were less likely to be the object of negative gossip (Ellwardt et al. 2012). Gossip was also more likely to be about communion-related characteristics (warmth, morality) than about agency-related characteristics (assertiveness, competence) and was more likely to be negative than positive (Martinescu et al. 2022). Along with negatively impacting a target individual's reputation, such negative workplace gossip has been linked with poorer workplace relationships, lower well-being, and less engagement (Wax et al. 2022). Thus, gossip stands out as a particularly potent and consequential source of workplace reputations.

Culture and Reputations

Cultural psychology has highlighted how cultures differ in their regard for reputations (Kim et al. 2010). Specifically, researchers have differentiated between face cultures, honor cultures, and dignity cultures. In face cultures (e.g., Japan, Hong Kong), individuals place strong emphasis on their relative position in the social hierarchy as the basis for determining individuals' worth. Such societies are described as having strong consensus about individuals' place in this hierarchy and exert strong pressures for people to avoid self-perceptions that are more positive than their reputations. Honor cultures (which are sometimes described as a subclass of face cultures; e.g., Armenia, Saudi Arabia) have a similar emphasis on determining worth based on one's reputation, but honor is comparatively more in flux than face—that is, one's station in the social hierarchy may regularly be challenged and defended. In contrast, dignity cultures (e.g., the Netherlands, Canada) tend to emphasize an intrinsic, equal value conveyed to everyone at birth. These cultures tend to view negative evaluations from others as impositions on their sovereignty, although some have noted that dignity values may exist more as an individual difference than as a distinguishing cultural feature (Smith et al. 2021). This cross-cultural research highlights important ways that reputations may function differently across societies, wherein reputations may produce stronger consensus and impact on personal well-being (face cultures) or be more strongly associated with competition and dominance (honor cultures).

Beyond cultural differences in the importance of reputations, cultures may differ in the processes through which persons are perceived and reputations are formed (Goyal & De Keersmaecker 2022). Freeman et al. (2009) emphasize the important role that perceptions serve as an affordance to action and note that culture is tied to the value of those affordances. Accordingly, they note that culture plays a role in (a) promoting accuracy of detecting emotional expressions within one's culture (Elfenbein & Ambady 2002), (b) shaping how dominance is perceived, and (c) determining how social groups are valued. Cultures also differ in how cues are used, wherein researchers found that East Asian samples tend to be more automatized toward making situational attributions for targets' behaviors than are Western samples (Knowles et al. 2001) and are more inclined to view targets holistically within a broader social context (Bjornsdottir et al. 2017). Unfortunately, relatively little work has been done that would extend some of these process differences to comparing the accuracy/consensus of reputations across cultures (Letzring 2021), making such explorations rife for future research.

AN INTEGRATIVE APPROACH: THE TRAIT-REPUTATION-IDENTITY MODEL

The preceding sections highlight the complexity of the numerous components and origins of reputations. Although interesting, this complexity presents challenges for researchers looking to isolate the proximal effects of any particular source on perceptions and reputations and their distal effects on workplace outcomes. For example, does the link between a reputation for conscientiousness and job performance reflect the impact of the substantive conscientiousness trait or the effects of impression management tactics to create a conscientiousness reputation? Similarly, how can researchers separate bias in stereotypes from the so-called kernel of truth?

One useful tool for bridging these disparate research traditions is the Trait-Reputation-Identity (TRI) model, which enables understanding the unique etiologies and outcomes of self- and informant reports of personality (McAbee & Connelly 2016). The TRI model relies on the use of bifactor structural equation modeling to distinguish between three sources of variance available across self- and observer ratings of a particular personality characteristic (see **Figure 2**): (a) The Trait factor captures consensual information shared across all rating sources, (b) the Identity factor reflects information that is unique to the self, and (c) the Reputation factor reflects information that is shared among observers but distinct from the target's self-views. The TRI model integrates a variety of theoretical elements outlined in the preceding sections. As in accuracy research, the TRI model uses consensus (i.e., loadings on a common factor) to reflect accuracy while simultaneously modeling distinct perspectives of each individual rater (i.e., error). It also incorporates insights from the SOKA model that self- and informant reports may be differentially accurate in rating a given trait and from socioanalytic theory in measuring Identity and Reputation factors. The TRI model is also flexible and can be adapted. For example, McAbee & Connelly (2016) outline how the model in **Figure 2** might be augmented with zero-acquaintance ratings as a mechanism for separating substance and bias in stereotypes. Similarly, comparing TRI model parameters between

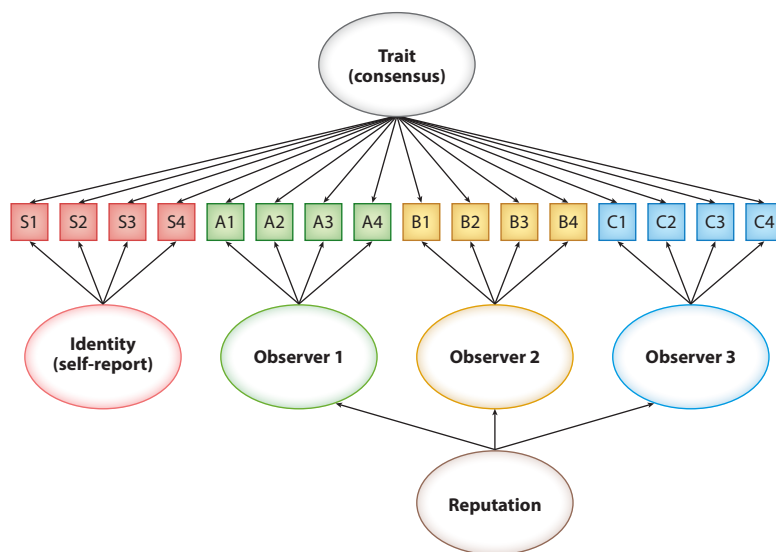


Figure 2

The Trait-Reputation-Identity model, a bifactor latent variable model for separating shared and unique perspectives in multi-rater measures. Figure adapted from McAbee & Connelly (2016) with permission from the American Psychological Association; no further reproduction or distribution is permitted.

observers who have versus have not gossiped about a particular target would provide a nuanced approach to studying the effects of communication networks on reputations.

Fitting the TRI model to multirater data permits researchers to distill Trait, Reputation, and Identity factors and also to directly estimate a variety of parameters. First, the loadings on each factor can be used to estimate the percentage of variance explained by Trait, Reputation, and Identity factors. For example, consistent with RAM and SOKA, the Trait factor accounts for substantial variance for the high-observability/low-evaluativeness trait of extraversion, but Identity is stronger for low-observability traits (e.g., openness, neuroticism) and Reputation is quite strong among the highly evaluative trait of agreeableness (McAbee & Connelly 2016). Second, Trait, Reputation, and Identity factors can be correlated with other variables, permitting researchers to examine the unique etiologies and outcomes of each component. For example, Connelly et al. (2022) examined whether job performance is tied to personality more through Trait, Reputation, or Identity factors (see the next section for elaboration). Third, examining the patterns of loadings across items/measures provides a basis for judging what is the most salient element of each factor.

The TRI model has also been applied in many domains outside of the Big Five personality traits, such as research on political will (Blickle et al. 2018) and the Dark Triad (Lämmle et al. 2021). Recently, a similar model (the Leadership Arena–Reputation–Identity model) has been applied to leadership assessments in order to estimate the relative shared and unique contributions of leaders' (self), supervisors', peers', and subordinates' leadership perspectives, finding that supervisors consistently contributed the most unique information (compared to peers, subordinates, and the self) for understanding leaders' ratings (Vergauwe et al. 2022). Thus, the TRI model and its adaptations provide a powerful and novel tool for integratively studying the origins, defining elements, and outcomes of workplace reputations.

WORKPLACE OUTCOMES OF REPUTATIONS

To this point we have discussed definitional issues surrounding reputations in the workplace and various ways in which perceivers form judgments of those reputations with respect to accuracy and error. However, reputations also have important consequences for those that hold them. Here we highlight three primary areas in which reputations impact employees' work-relevant outcomes: predicting job performance, career success, and employee well-being. As noted above, criteria such as job performance can also be viewed through a reputational lens, wherein its measures contain both substantive performance variation and perceptual distortions. Researchers in these domains have tended to interpret associations between reputations and performance as being driven by links with substantive variance in performance and have generally adopted designs to facilitate these interpretations (e.g., relative to measures of reputation predictors, using criterion measures from separate raters, contexts, and/or temporal periods). Thus, we particularly highlight studies with greater psychological separation between predictor and criterion measures.

Job Performance

Personality traits (e.g., the Big Five) are well recognized as important predictors of performance-related outcomes (e.g., Barrick & Mount 1991). Although most of this research has focused on self-reports, seminal meta-analyses have demonstrated that informant reports of personality traits demonstrate stronger relations with key performance outcomes than those observed for self-reports of these same traits (Connelly & Ones 2010, Oh et al. 2011). Moreover, these meta-analyses demonstrated that although informant reports of the Big Five predict incremental variance in overall job performance above and beyond self-reports, the converse was not observed. This research has been reified by several primary studies that underscore relations between informant

reports of personality and various work outcomes (e.g., Connelly et al. 2022, Kluemper et al. 2015, Wihler et al. 2023). For example, Connelly et al. (2022) demonstrated the usefulness of the TRI model for predicting performance outcomes in applied settings. Specifically, they examined associations between TRI models of the Big Five and the target's coworker ratings of organizational citizenship behaviors, supervisor performance ratings, and official academic grade point averages. Findings indicated that all three sources of variance decomposed within the TRI model (i.e., Trait, Identity, and Reputation) were related to at least one of the outcomes examined across the Big Five traits. Most notable, however, was the general pattern of findings that the Reputation factors for conscientiousness and agreeableness, in particular, were the primary drivers of performance outcomes, even over and above the findings for the Trait factors for these domains. Thus, personality assessments, when viewed through the lens of reputations, become more potent predictors.

A rejoinder to some of the potential of informant reports is that the same drivers of reputation, as viewed through personality assessments, operate in judgments of overall performance (see, e.g., Hogan & Shelton 1998). However, several studies have demonstrated the unique and powerful prediction of personality reputations formed at different times and in different contexts. For example, personality perceptions predicted performance, even when coming from personal acquaintances who never observed targets in the workplace (Connelly & Hülshager 2012) or in predictive designs prior to measuring the criteria (Connelly et al. 2022, Zimmerman et al. 2010). Thus, although there may be similarities in the perceptual processes involved when forming judgments of reputations and performance, reputations' prediction of performance transcends contextual and temporal features.

Although we have primarily relied on the realm of personality assessment in our discussion of reputations in the workplace, we do note that there are alternative means by which reputations are assessed at work. This conforms with Lievens & Sackett's (2017) modular approach to selection systems wherein a particular construct can be assessed by multiple methods (see also Lievens 2017). In particular, reference checks and letters of recommendations provide raters with an initial impression of applicants' reputations through the lens of (potentially) well-acquainted informants. Indeed, these pre-employment assessments usefully predict key outcomes in the workplace (e.g., Hedricks et al. 2013, Kuncel et al. 2014). Beyond these tools drawing from well-known acquaintances, several well-established procedures solicit person perceptions that are used in making selection decisions. Specifically, theories surrounding accurate person judgments have been used to inform how assessment centers and employment interviews are typically designed (e.g., Blackman 2017, Christiansen et al. 2013). For example, assessment centers and interviews have long relied on the judgments of multiple raters as a means of obtaining trait-relevant perceptions. Moreover, these assessments attempt to elicit specific behavioral cues from applicants as a lens into traits that will manifest in the workplace, consistent with the notion that past behaviors communicate critical information about reputations. Notably, it would be interesting to explore the extent to which these various selection methods offer consistent versus unique perspectives on employees' reputations at work.

Career Success

Beyond relations with job performance outcomes, researchers have suggested that reputations should be related to beneficial employee outcomes (e.g., Ferris et al. 2003; Zinko et al. 2007, 2012). In their review of personal reputation in the workplace, Zinko et al. (2007) posited a number of direct and indirect outcomes that might result from having a positive global reputation at work. Specifically, these authors argued that more positive reputations would be directly related to greater discretionary behavior (i.e., autonomy), power, and higher compensation among employees possessing such reputations. Moreover, these benefits might then translate into greater

opportunities for promotions and career success. Several of these propositions were subsequently tested (Zinko et al. 2012). These authors observed that informant perceptions of overall reputations were positively related to (distinct) informant ratings of power, autonomy, and supervisor ratings of career success (e.g., rate of promotions). As such, these authors provide preliminary evidence that generalized reputations can and do manifest themselves in direct benefits for employees who enjoy such reputations.

We note, however, that this research has thus far focused on how an employee's global reputation manifests in potential benefits in the workplace. Much less is directly known regarding how employees' reputations for specific characteristics relate to key markers of career success (e.g., promotions, salary). Drawing from the broader literature on career success, however, Ng et al. (2005) meta-analytically identified several personality traits and other characteristics associated with reputations (e.g., skills, education) that were positively related to employee salary, promotion, career satisfaction, and subjective career success. Yet much of the research supporting these meta-analyses draws primarily from the use of self-reports of these reputational characteristics. Given the pattern of findings for observer reports of personality and performance outcomes (Connelly et al. 2022, Oh et al. 2011), we suspect that informant perceptions of these characteristics would also more strongly relate to objective and subjective markers of career success, although this position has yet to be formally tested. Future research should seek to test what specific facets of reputation relate to employees' career success outcomes and the processes by which reputations lead to success.

Well-Being

Of these three research areas, the association between reputations and well-being is the least well established. One line of thinking has emphasized the correspondence between reputations and self-views/identity as central for one's well-being (Human & Biesanz 2013; Human et al. 2014, 2019), with several plausible mechanisms. First, reputation-identity correspondence may reflect a form of expressed authenticity (Mignault et al. 2023). This authenticity has potential consequences, as research has shown a positive association between authenticity and psychological well-being (Sutton 2020). Second, self-verification theory suggests that people are motivated to be accurately perceived by others, and that such accurate perceptions confirm their sense of self, leading to higher satisfaction and well-being (Swann 2011). Third, reputation-identity correspondence may indicate individuals who avoid bias in their self-views that is associated with narcissistic tendencies (Carlson et al. 2011). Fourth, in line with socioanalytic theory (Hogan 1996, Hogan & Blickle 2013), reputation-identity correspondence could indicate that individuals have successfully managed the impressions they create among perceivers, thereby facilitating achieving their social goals. However, research regarding the association between reputation-identity correspondence and various well-being outcomes has primarily developed outside of the organizational psychology literature [e.g., among married couples (Claxton et al. 2012)], highlighting the pressing need for future research on this topic.

A second line of thinking has emphasized the specific content of reputations themselves. For example, research on adolescents' reputations has shown that students who are viewed negatively by their peers (e.g., as aggressive or withdrawn) are more likely to be disliked, feel lonely, be victimized, and have fewer reciprocal friendships (Gorman et al. 2011). Naturally, these consequences may extend to adult relationships in the workplace, where ostracism, incivility, and other forms of negative work behaviors impinge on job satisfaction and employee mental health. Conversely, having a generally positive reputation among colleagues may confer benefits such as increased liking and social support, thereby enhancing employees' overall workplace attitudes and well-being. However, we are unaware of research examining how the development of such reputations may lead to these outcomes.

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

The preceding review describing the origins and outcomes of workplace reputations highlights several practical implications for how organizations assess, develop, and manage talent in their workforce. First, reputations are an important component of personnel selection in both formal ways (e.g., reference checks, letters of recommendation) and informal ways (inquiring in a network, examining social media). Although researchers have often viewed the validity of some of these traditional reputation assessments with suspicion, the research reviewed here points to a much higher ceiling for the predictive validity of reputations when systematically assessing specific job-relevant constructs via established and validated measures, rated by well-acquainted informants (e.g., Hedricks et al. 2013, Zimmerman et al. 2010). At the same time, reputational measures open up susceptibility to stereotypes, biases, and libel in ways that corresponding self-report measures usually do not; organizations would likely be well served to proceed cautiously in determining what kind of information to collect and which raters to draw from. In addition, traditional perception-based selection tools such as interviews and assessment centers can be interpreted as microreputations that are similar to studies that solicit thin-slice perceptions. Viewing these measures in this way highlights the complex sources of variance in these measures and also serves as a bridge for connecting the first impressions an applicant makes to how they may establish a reputation within the organization.

In addition, reputation research holds important implications for how organizations develop and manage their employees. Given the importance of reputations for one's success and well-being, reputation assessments may provide a valuable feedback and coaching tool. Multisource (i.e., 360-degree) performance feedback represents one manifestation of such feedback and coaching that is already widely adopted, but developmental feedback could benefit from more breadth in the reputational constructs assessed. For example, assessing workplace personality reputations might provide greater context and direction for an individual who struggles to meet deadlines by identifying whether the upstream origins are an inability to manage stress versus perfectionistic fixations versus procrastination/unreliability. Contrasting reputational assessments with self-reports could be a powerful tool for identifying individuals' blind spots. At a more macro level, organizations could also analyze demographic differences in reputational assessments as a mechanism for identifying stereotypes and barriers for protected groups. For example, finding that an organization's female employees' reputations for being emotional consistently exceed corresponding self-reports might point to specific negative workplace stereotypes that the organization could take active steps to redress. Thus, even beyond personnel selection, organizations could benefit substantially from incorporating a broader base of reputational assessments for their existing employees.

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

This review article has covered research from organizational psychology, organizational behavior, personality psychology, and social psychology. Despite this breadth of research, much about workplace reputations remains unknown. In the sidebar titled Key Directions for Future Research on Workplace Reputations, we identify 13 broad research questions that we believe would be particularly novel and informative in directing future research, organized around five general themes.

First, although the field of person perception has an array of tools and models for examining the origins and processes of reputation, they have rarely been applied to study reputations in the workplace. Accordingly, extending designs that have examined the relative contributions of different sources of reputation information and the impact of reputational contexts to samples

KEY DIRECTIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH ON WORKPLACE REPUTATIONS

Workplace Reputational Origins and Processes

1. What is the relative contribution of substantive attributes, impression management strategies, stereotypes, perceptual errors, and gossip to workplace reputations?
2. What contextual boundaries delineate workplace reputations, and what aspects of reputations are most context dependent versus context transcendent?
3. How do individuals resolve discrepancies between workplace reputations and their identity?
4. What role do reputations play in mediating interpersonal or social-cognitive processes and workplace outcomes?

Workplace Reputation Outcomes

5. How do workplace reputations relate to a broader array of workplace outcomes, including job attitudes, counterproductivity, organizational fit, and turnover?
6. How do workplace reputations for a broader array of individual differences (including knowledge, abilities, skills, values, and interests) predict workplace criteria? Do reputations for these attributes predict incrementally beyond more objective and/or self-report measures?

Measuring Reputations

7. How strong are consensus and accuracy among coworkers' judgments for individual differences beyond personality traits?
8. Which informants are the most accurate source of workplace reputations?
9. How susceptible are measures of reputations to faking in high stakes contexts?

Reputations as Dynamic Entities

10. How do workplace reputations change over time?
11. What can organizations and individuals do to change an inaccurate reputation?

Culture and Demographics

12. How do workplace reputations' content, consensus, accuracy, and predictive validity differ across cultures?
13. How do workplace reputations' content, consensus, accuracy, and predictive validity differ across demographic groups?

using coworkers as informants would be particularly valuable. Notably, the workplace may offer attributes (e.g., leadership, job knowledge) and contexts (supervisors versus subordinates, professional versus social) that are uniquely salient for workplace reputations. In addition, examining how workplace reputations fit in with one's sense of identity would be novel and valuable, particularly with regard to how reputation feedback can be a generative source of information.

Across much of the literature we review, reputations have often been an implied—but unmeasured—mediator linking personality and social cognition processes to consequential work outcomes. For example, researchers studying workplace gossip might examine links between negatively communicating about a target and the target's career success. Here, the presumed mechanism is that gossip changes the way a target is consensually viewed at work (i.e., reputations) that in turn yields more negative performance ratings and career opportunities, although such research may forego measuring the content of a target's workplace reputation entirely. Although

methodologically demanding, neglecting measuring reputations directly strikes us as a missed opportunity, particularly for demonstrating the real-world implications of many of the processes that have been documented in experimental research. One notable exception to this trend comes from research on impression management and organizational politics. For example, Zinko et al. (2012) examined reputation as a mediator between antecedents (time, human capital, and social effectiveness) and outcomes (autonomy, power, and career success). Designs such as this are powerful in demonstrating that antecedents and outcomes are linked through reputations rather than via other mechanisms.

Second, as reflected in the volume of research reviewed here, there is a considerable imbalance of research attention that has been directed toward studying the origins of reputations relative to their workplace outcomes. For employed adults, colleagues are the social group that people spend the most time interacting with, so it follows that the outcomes of the workplace reputations that individuals build through these interactions would be critical for one's success and well-being. In this vein, organizational psychologists are well positioned to offer a multitude of yet-unexamined workplace reputational outcomes such as job attitudes, counterproductivity, organizational fit, and turnover. In addition, most workplace outcome research has focused on reputations of personality traits, but examining how reputations of other individual difference attributes link with workplace outcomes would be similarly valuable.

Third, the workplace reputation literature would substantially benefit from further extensions of person perception research related to measurement. In particular, foundational measurement research related to consensus and accuracy of workplace reputations has focused predominantly on personality and on job performance, although there are a host of individual differences likely to be important for workplace reputations that remain understudied. Similarly, it remains unclear which informants provide the most accuracy in judging workplace reputations. Thus, research examining the effects of context on workplace reputations would serve well to inform such choices (e.g., do informants need to be acquainted with the target in the workplace to provide useful insights about workplace reputations? Is observing a target in a particular role or scenario more informative for a particular attribute?). Finally, relatively little research has examined the impact of faking on informant ratings, nor has research examined how the validity of informant ratings might be impacted by high stakes assessment scenarios. For applications soliciting reputations for personnel selection, research on informant response distortion would be particularly prescient.

Fourth, researchers across many of these literatures have tended to examine reputations as static entities. However, workplace reputations are certainly dynamic, and the factors affecting them assuredly shift from initial impressions of an applicant to reputations earned during initial socialization phases to events that shift and overturn more stabilized reputations. Accordingly, longitudinal studies of workplace reputations are well poised to offer much needed insights. In addition, the workplace represents an important setting for understanding how either an individual or an organization might work to change an inaccurate reputation.

Fifth, the broader tendencies in psychology and management to rely on WEIRD (Western, educated, industrialized, rich, democratic) samples extend to research on workplace reputations. Overreliance on such samples is particularly problematic for this topic, as cultural psychology has often underscored the importance associated with a person's reputation as a defining feature of a culture. Thus, there is strong theory that should lead researchers to expect workplace reputation findings not to generalize across cultures, and we encourage international collaborations that would facilitate cross-cultural comparisons when studying workplace reputations. Similarly, the meaningful role that stereotypes can play in workplace reputations highlights how important it may be to not assume that findings will generalize across demographic groups. For example, researchers might study whether relationships with well-being differ when workplace reputations

are measured from in-group versus out-group members. Thus, workplace reputations represent a valuable domain for researchers to adopt cross-sample and cross-group comparisons.

CONCLUSION

In this review, we have taken a very broad view of reputations, their origins, and their workplace consequences. As noted at the outset, research on reputations spans a diverse array of subliterations that tend to be structurally siloed, use diverse methodologies, and offer different implications about the role of reputations in the workplace. We view these different literatures as complementary rather than competing, and reputation researchers will be well served to consider alternate interpretations of their findings that might be offered from adopting the perspectives of neighboring subliterations. Organizational psychologists are well positioned to integrate insights from personality, impression management, socioanalytic theory, stereotyping/prejudice, social cognition, communication, and culture for understanding the components and consequences of workplace reputations. Despite their complex nature, workplace reputations hold great importance for employees and organizations.

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